would chat with me. On learning I was a new father, Sarabhai congratulated me.

Suddenly he fell silent. Then, as if pronouncing the result of an intense introspection, he said in a barely audible voice, 'I was not a good father… never a good husband,' he said. 'They put up with me because they don't have a choice.'

Those words continue to ring in my mind for two reasons. One, was one of the rare occasions when I had seen Sarabhai, the cheerful man who always linked everything he spoke to the nation's growth, being pensive and philosophical. Two, today I believe that I have not done justice to my family, as a husband or a father. And I have nobody to blame for this than me.

My son wanted to be a doctor, but I never found enough time to be with him and guide him to his goal. Not that it would have ensured him a medical seat, but I neither prompted him to work hard or myself earned enough then to spend on a private medical college admission. Sankar went on to graduate in commerce and took a post-graduate degree. I helped him set up a business in LPG distribution. Today he runs a successful business, but I am yet to get rid of that prick of conscience.

My daughter Geetha was born on 24 June 1971, a year after I returned from Princeton. She did not want to be a doctor or an engineer, the two professions then considered prestigious and just every parent's matter of pride. She studied home science. She, however, did not want to confine herself to home, so she tried out a few things including garment business, but finally discovered her passion for training in Montessori schools.

It was by chance, however, that she became a teacher. I had gone with her for her daughter's admission to National Public School in Bangalore. The chairman of the school, K P Gopalakrishnan, had regards for me and readily offered a seat for my granddaughter Shruthi, who later went on to become a doctor. He advised Geetha to do a Montessori teaching course, and here she found her calling.

Geetha had been writing letters to me when I was in jail. Through them she tried to infuse courage. These came as a solace to me in a different way.